

Public controversy

Through this time, Monteverdi had continued to publish books of madrigals that were sufficiently innovative to provoke notable public controversy. In 1600, conservative music scholar Giovanni Artusi launched an outspoken attack on “the imperfections of modern music,” accusing Monteverdi in particular of crude dissonance and violation of the proper rules of musical composition. The supporters of “modern music,” including the composer himself, responded by identifying two equally valid musical “practices.” The first, which had predominated in the previous century, followed strict rules of polyphony, irrespective of the text being sung. The new “seconda pratica,” which Monteverdi had been criticized for following, gave precedence to the emotional implications of the text, using dissonance and other departures from traditional musical rules to bring out the sense and feeling of the words.

Monteverdi was finally accorded the coveted post of director of music at Mantua in 1601 and in the following year he was honored with Mantuan citizenship. In 1607, the duke’s son Francesco Gonzaga commissioned Monteverdi to create a theatrical entertainment for the carnival season in Mantua. Such works, later called operas (see box), had been performed in other Italian cities, so the Gonzagas were keeping up with fashion. A variant on the Greek myth of Orpheus and Eurydice, Monteverdi’s *L’Orfeo* combined orchestral and choral writing with long recitatives and arias to powerful effect. His first large-scale work, it was an immediate success. He wrote a second opera, *L’Arianna*, the following year. The only section of this